fuel from Libya, and missile technology for the delivery of nuclear-armed missiles from North Korea and China. Zulfi vowed "to eat grass" rather than to reduce the funding required by Pakistan's Atomic Energy Agency to carry out his highest new priority mission. He hoped to beat India at acquiring enough plutonium to test an atomic bomb, but India crossed that finish line much earlier than Pakistan, announcing its first underground nuclear explosion on 18 May 1974, ironically, the "birthday" of the Buddha.[4]

In 1974, Zulfi Bhutto was at the peak of his power. That year, he hosted thirty-eight heads of Islamic states in Lahore at a lavish conference whose most honored guests included King Faisal of Saudi Arabia, Presidents Hafiz al-Assad of Syria and Anwar Sadat of Egypt, Colonel Qaddafi of Libya, and Prime Minister Mujibur Rahman of Bangladesh. Bhutto's Pakistan had become the unifier of the Islamic world. China and North Korea were Pakistan's closest East Asian allies, and Bhutto proudly spoke of it as Asia's "midmost nation," with the mission of "mediating conflicts." The atomic bomb he sponsored would be an Islamic bomb, he assured both Qaddafi and Assad.

Zulfi thought of himself as a combination of Napoleon and Mao. His appetite for wine and women was as insatiable as his lust for power. Wiser compatriots cautioned him against his intoxicated outbursts of violence and threats to leave political enemies with "no legs" to stand on. Bhutto believed himself impervious to arrest, however, no matter what crimes he committed. His fatal mistake was his promotion of a seemingly unambitious junior lieutenant general to serve as Pakistan's chief of army staff (COAS).

General Zia ul-Haq was a devout and austere Muslim, a modest soldier, who had just been promoted to lieutenant general when Bhutto reached below five senior officers to elevate Zia to the post of COAS. All those senior generals were then forced to retire, shocked at Bhutto's wild choice. One of them considered Zia the army's "best sycophant"; another called him "a dark horse." Benazir called him "the devil," but that was after he had arrested and later hanged her father. Blinded by his own hubris, Bhutto never imagined that Zia, who always smiled at and bowed to him, would dare bite off the head of the leader who had so generously promoted him.

Zia waited patiently before arresting Bhutto, never contradicting or refusing to obey his prime minister until 1977, when Bhutto decided to renew his popular mandate, ordering nationwide elections. Like Nixon,